

Episode 40: Once Again Setting Aside "Colour Direction" for a Bit to Talk About *Hakaba Kitaro*

Uh, it's been 2 weeks? 3 weeks? since my last update (sweat).

In my last manuscript I wrote "Ah, I want to see snow," and wouldn't you know it, the very next day it suddenly snowed (bitter laugh), and after that, we've had this lovely Tokyo weather with snow falling every week.

While I was going "Yay yay (joy)" over this snow, Akimoto-san, who's handling colour direction for *Hakaba Kitaro*, gave me a look of complete disbelief saying "What?! Unbelievable!" (bitter laugh). She's from Aomori.

Those of us born and raised in Tokyo welcome snow falling as a "winter event" and even celebrate it somewhat. We think "It'll melt away soon anyway, so it's fine to have this 'event' 2-3 times a winter."

However, in Tokyo with its many building shadows, when we get half-hearted snowfall, the road surfaces freeze the next morning and "Demon King Ice Barn" descends, so you have to be careful (bitter laugh).

Well then.

I'm thinking about continuing the story of "Colour Direction" credits... but I'm still too busy with actual work including *Hakaba* to properly take time to write the manuscript (crying). Sorry about that. So I'll talk a bit more about *Hakaba*.

In the middle of this cold winter, *Hakaba Kitaro* is going great. Thanks to everyone, the viewership ratings in the Kanto region have exceeded 5%! Man, thank you all so much. This is actually a pretty amazing number. Just looking at 5% might seem small, but in the first place, not many people watch TV during late night hours. According to

occupation rate data, one out of every five people who had their TV on during this time slot was watching *Hakaba*.

Well, I don't want to just keep talking about ratings, but we staff are really happy that so many people are watching. When you make something with full confidence and effort, you naturally want lots of people to see it. So I keep hoping the broadcast area will expand even more.

By the way, this *Hakaba* apparently also has a high industry viewership rating (laugh), and people from other production companies I have relationships with often call out "I watched it. It's great!" when they see me.

Though, well, since I'm going around promoting it everywhere, there's probably some lip service involved (laugh).

This week's broadcast is episode 6. We're finally at the halfway point, heading into the second half.

This *Hakaba Kitaro* is basically structured as complete single episodes, and each episode introduces quite a few new characters. The setting work and colour decision-making for these is pretty tough. For some characters, there are colour prints in the original or coloured versions in Mizuki-sensei's art books, but most references are from the black-and-white original. So first I put on colours, then series director Chioka, character designer Yamamuro, and the episode's director all groan "hmm, hmm" while we decide things.

And as I mentioned before, this production adds texture and filter effects during photography for screen effects, so the colouring-stage colour tones and the actual screen colour tones change dramatically. So we have to reverse-calculate while considering that when deciding colours.

How much do they change? Well, first, "blue" becomes almost "grey" (laugh). So in episode 1, I failed by doing a blue-tone night colour at the beginning (explosion). Even in normal scene colouring, Nezumi Otoko's clothes (or rather, cloth) look yellowish on screen, but the actual painted colour is quite flashy fluorescent yellow-green. The red jacket Trump Jui was wearing was painted in shocking pink!

Because of this, even when I try to make characters stand out by putting flashy colours on jackets and shirts, it doesn't achieve the balance I'm hoping for, which is frustrating.

Since the colour saturation is so poor, for example, the yellow of Kitaro's vest and the red of Neko's skirt are actually shot twice—once with the filter, then overlaid again just for those parts.

Oh, incidentally, Kitaro and Medama Oyaji aren't really affected by the filter much. The colours we paint are generally the impression you get.

I hope you can enjoy *Hakaba Kitaro* while imagining such things (laugh).

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